

Common sense



Miracles such as the feeding of the 5,000 apparently defy the laws of nature, but it is more likely our senses are being deceived or the story has been made up.

A distinguishing feature of British empiricism was its appeal to common sense. This tradition of no-nonsense reasoning had its roots in William of Ockham's reduction of unnecessary propositions and abstractions and Francis Bacon's methodical examination of evidence for any hypothesis (see [Ockham's razor and Buridan's ass](#) and [Bacon and the scientific method](#)). Locke repeatedly referred to 'the plain facts of the matter', and

while Berkeley's 'subjective idealism' was an exception to this rule, his ideas were subsequently refuted by the down-to-earth Hume. But Hume realized that logical reasoning often leads us to conclusions that are difficult to accept, and in those cases we must use our experience to weigh up the evidence and make judgements. He was also sceptical of all things supernatural: 'miracles' that, by definition, violate the laws of nature derived from our experience of the world. Common sense (also part of our experience of the world) tells us that the likelihood that an event contradicting all our experience is miraculous is less than the probability that our senses have been deceived or that the account of it is false.